

more accurate measurement of sound, and the difference between, say, 440 Hz (the note A above the middle C in concert music) and 441 Hz is not noticeable by the human ear. Thus, though the pitch of two notes may appear to be the same, the frequencies may not be.

Tempo: The speed at which music is played. If you listen to a song carefully, you will find patterns in the beats, and this defines the tempo of the song. If you speed up the beats, the tempo increases. In Audacity you will come across ways to change the tempo of a song, by either increasing or decreasing the pitch, or by keeping pitch constant and increasing or decreasing the length of the song.

Track: Normally used as another word for song, but when editing audio, you can mix various songs by putting them in the same file, but in different “tracks.” Here, tracks are merely a component of a final output. Musicians always record each instrument and vocal on different “tracks,” so that each can be tweaked individually and then mixed to get that perfect balance of sound.

5.4 Waveforms

The next thing you need to know about when you want to do a little basic audio editing is how to read waveforms. This may look and sound complicated, but is actually a lot easier than it appears.

First of all, let's take a look at a typical waveform of a song and compare it to the waveform of a constant pitch—that is, a single note playing constantly with the same loudness.

As you can see, music has a lot of spikes and dips in waveform. Now, when editing this waveform, such as when cutting and splicing, you need to keep two things in mind—tempo and amplitude. It takes a trained musical ear to be able to tell the tempo of a song, but you can do this too. When zooming into the waveform, watch for patterns in it. Also, listen to the track as it moves through the